Letters to The Departed

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by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

After peace has been restored, nothing but mundane problems become the only thing for the Best Friends Squad to take care of.

This time, the Queen's aunt was found passed out on the floor, and it's up to them to figure out what happened!

And for that, they may need to read a few personal letters the Head Sorceress never sent…

Notes

Well… finally managed to post this for the weekly prompt of *checks notes* the last week of last year XD

Anyways, at least I did something, no? <("^_^)

In any case, uh, I hope you enjoy this little one-shot!

See the end of the work for more notes

When Glimmer stepped into her aunt's room, she felt a bit of a chill.

She had never walked in there alone before. Just a few times visited her Aunt Casta, but that happened so rarely too…

Being there *without* her present felt so *wrong*.

But she had to. It was her duty.

Her father was too worried and distressed to do it himself.

So it was up to Glimmer now.

—Alright— she sighed. —Let's get this over with… Just a look at anything that might be important, and then…— she told herself.

But then, what?

Maybe she could discuss her findings with her friends before going to her father.

That did seem like a good idea, actually.

In any case, she had work to do.

After maybe half an hour, Glimmer walked out of the room.

Relief washed over her as she closed the door behind her.

The feeling of wrongness finally left her.

No matter how many times she told herself she was only trying to help her aunt, it hadn't been any easier to go over her desk, drawers, closet…

And now, she had a handful of written paper sheets.

Letters.

She had hardly given the first ones a quick look and it was enough to convince her she had to take these and go over them more carefully.

These letters could be the key to understanding what had happened to Castaspella.

Queen Glimmer appeared in Bright Moon’s former war room and let out a deep sigh.

—Oh, you're back— Bow noticed, standing up from his chair so he could open one for her to join them. Only he, Adora, and Catra were there at the time, so they could speak privately, as planned. —So? Anything of use? Clues?— he inquired, sitting down again.

—Hopefully— she sighed again, setting down the letters. —There was absolutely nothing out of the ordinary, no signs of fight, no strange potions, weird plants, or… literally anything that could have harmed her…

—But?— Adora asked, eyeing the letters.

—*But* then I found these inside a drawer.

—And those are… Notes? Or a messy journal?— Bow tried to guess.

—Unsent letters— Glimmer clarified.

—Why are they relevant?— Catra decided to ask, confused.

—Well, that's… the thing. I wasn't going to- I didn't *want* to look through her correspondence, but something caught my eye and… I don't know why I have the suspicion this is important— the Queen admitted. —Just, look at the first one. I skimmed the first three and they are similar, but… there may be more I'm missing.

Curious now, Catra reached for the first letter and almost immediately saw what Glimmer meant. Her eyes opened wide as she read the intended recipient.

—What the- Sparkles, why would you aunt- But…

—I'm as clueless as you, trust me— she interrupted.

—What does it say?— Adora then asked.

—See for yourself— Catra scoffed, still in disbelief.

—Huh? She wrote to… *Shadow Weaver*!?— she exclaimed. —And this is from just a bit after… everything ended.

—Yeah— Glimmer nodded. —There are about half a dozen letters and, from the dates, it's clear Auntie's been writing them the past two months quite regularly— she explained. —It may be nothing, or… well, I'm almost convinced there's something important about these.

—Are we sure we can read these?— Bow asked, concerned.

—Well, this first one is just a summary of the first few days of peace in Etheria— Adora revealed. —I don't think there's anything wrong, maybe the Head Sorceress wanted to, uh, put her thoughts into words and-and… uh…

—Why write letters that can't be sent?— Catra inquired.

—I actually… think that it makes a lot of sense— Adora insisted, blushing. —I may have… uh… written a few things I wish I could have sent you… back in… my first year here— she admitted.

—Alright, I'll bite: so you wrote to me because you weren't used to us being apart. Makes sense! But why does Sparkles' aunt write to that old hag she barely knew?— Catra insisted, not quite angry but rather so confused it frustrated her. —It makes no sense.

—Maybe they *did* become friends?

—*When*!?— all three of them asked, equally confused.

—Listen, we were told they left on their own to investigate at least a day before we returned from space, right?— Adora began. —And then it took them another two days to return? At least?

—At least, yes— Glimmer nodded.

—Well, we have no idea what happened during that time. And I know it sounds insane, but… they did seem friendly enough afterwards!— Adora went on.

—No one would become friends that quickly- Not with Shadow Weaver— Catra refuted.

—Some of our friends have literally forged their friendships within hours— she pointed out. —So, yeah, I don't think anyone would ever befriend Shadow Weaver that quickly, but if it's days being around no one other than each other, at least an understanding will naturally develop— Adora insisted. —Or so I think…

—Alright, let's consider that possibility. Would that mean going through these letters is a possible way to find clues? Or am I totally wrong here?

—I think you may have a point, Glim— Bow immediately replied. —Here's what I think: Maybe not friendship as we understand it, but perhaps your aunt and Shadow Weaver had enough respect for each other to… trust each other?— he tried to explain. —As in, maybe Castaspella didn't feel comfortable talking to anyone else, and the thing with writing letters to someone who can't receive them is that, well, they also can't reply.

—Then what's the point?— Catra inquired, raising a brow.

—It's just a way to express herself, let out what she needs to say, all within a safe space that feels comfortable for her— Bow explained. —Which means, whatever happened to her, how she was feeling, or even if she noticed something strange that may be of use to us, these letters could let us know!

—Oh…— Adora let out. —So if the King's theory is right…

—We'll know reading these, yes.

—Bow, you're a genius— Glimmer thanked him, squeezing his hand. —Alright, Adora, what does that one say?

—Just what I said. The first days of peace, how things went, what the Princess Alliance decided to do, how… uh, how restoration plans where being made— she summarized. —And it ends with a comment about the peace being- No, wait, I read it wrong. It says "You were right; I don't notice the peace, not really". What does that mean?

—I have no idea— the Queen admitted, exchanging a glance with Bow.

—"Don't notice the peace", huh? I think I get it— Catra smirked. —Mystacor had that protection, uh, invisibility spell thing, right?— she asked, and everyone nodded. —Well, the only time Shadow Weaver herself tried to get Adora back was when you three went to Mystacor, and she infiltrated it. I was only tasked with keeping watch at the door, but still could notice, from what little I saw and heard, that it had to be a kingdom that's *far* from used to the war— she explained. —I'd bet anything that Shadow Weaver told Castaspella that she wouldn't notice the difference between how things were before defeating Prime, and how they are now.

—Oh, *that's* what you mean. Yeah, I agree— Glimmer nodded, laughing slightly. —I can imagine Auntie didn't like admitting that, though.

—Should we read the next one?— Adora asked, setting aside the letter she had.

—I'll go now— Catra decided, taking the topmost letter. Humming, she read it over in silence before raising a brow and snorting. —So, yeah, the Head Sorceress just rambled about some stuff that happened in Mystacor, apparently the council guys are "a bunch of morons", which *also* seems to be a comment Shadow Weaver made, and then closes with a few lines about us, Adora— she enumerated. —As if she'd want to know…

—I think she would— Adora muttered, looking down.

—Wouldn't ever admit it though— Glimmer chuckled.

—You may be giving her too much credit, seriously…— Catra insisted, arms folded.

—Well, in any case, that letter means *Casta* thinks she would want to know— Bow pointed out. —Which kinda supports the theory that they were more friendly than imagined— he then added, hesitant but out of incredulity mainly.

—Alright, sure, whatever— she scoffed, folding her arms. —Next letter…

—Okay! My turn— Glimmer sighed, a bit nervous again. She picked the letter on top, skimmed it, and then explained —Here she's… mostly telling her about Dad, how he's doing, recovering, and… how it feels to have him back. Then… she speaks about me as Queen of the new peaceful era.

—Good things, I hope?— Bow interrupted.

—Yeah— she chuckled. —Really nice things… It seems Auntie likes how we're giving former Horde soldiers a second chance— she went on. —And, well, this one concludes with her wondering how it would have been if… Shadow Weaver hadn't… you know…

—Yeah, I sometimes wonder that too— Adora admitted.

—Well, I *don't*— Catra lied, looking away as her tail moved back an forth.

—Alright! Guess next one is on me— Bow decided to say, before anyone could confront the magicat. He did as everyone before him, but soon his expression fell. —Wow, this one is sad *sad*— he let out, worried. —Why do I get the sad one?

—Tough luck. Now read it— Catra insisted, still annoyed.

—Sure— he sighed, clearly unhappy to comply. —Ok, so, I'm sorry, Glim, but your Aunt did become friends with Shadow Weaver from what I read here, and she's far from alright with her death, you know?

—What does that mean?

—This letter is all melancholic. She just… talks about stuff that happened when they were alone investigating, and well, it's all references that I obviously can't understand. But she… expresses very clearly that, well, that she felt true connection.

—You can't be serious— Catra scoffed, her disbelief trying to hide pain.

—I am, and so is Casta. Like, here she says that Shadow Weaver may be a jerk but at least was genuine, understood her even if she wouldn't behave like it, and above else, respected Casta, not out of obligation but out of some sort of serious acknowledgment of her— Bow explained, his sight fixed on the letter. Then, when he looked up, he noticed Catra's expression. —I'm sorry.

—Why are *you* sorry!?

—No, well, I mean…

—Listen, it-it's *great*! That woman was a real bitch to me all my life, but I guess someone managed to make her- what was the word? "Genuine"? Yeah, so she was *genuine* the last few days before fucking *dying*. That's *just* amazing!— Catra spat, angrier with each passing second. —So, no, don't be sorry. As always, *I'm* the one in the wrong here.

There was a tense silence for merely a moment that felt eternal, as Adora and Glimmer exchanged a glance, concerned.

—Of course not!— Bow scoffed, angry too. —No one is saying that! That's *not* what this means!

—Okay! Wait, calm down, you two— Adora chimed in. —First of all, Catra, you're not wrong. Alright? Second, Bow, can you maybe explain yourself a bit less…

—I'm not trying to be aggressive, Adora— he interrupted. —I'm just being serious. This isn't about whether Shadow Weaver was bad or not. That's not under discussion. This is just Casta's consideration, and it doesn't, by any means, erase all of what that woman did to you — he explained. —I apologized because I could see how reading this would make you feel

like Shadow Weaver wasn't "that bad", but that's *not* true. This is a biased view. It's about *their* relationship only. And I *know* Casta wouldn't invalidate your experience either!

There was silence for a moment again.

This time, Adora held Catra's hand tightly, while Glimmer looked down at the table, feeling a bit responsible.

—Thanks…

—Huh?

—Thanks, Arrow Boy— Catra repeated. —I guess… I took it too personal.

—Just a *tiny* bit…— he smirked. —Now, remember, we're doing this for Casta. No one is questioning you…

—Yeah, yeah…— she sighed. —Alright, I'll grab the next letter, then— she decided, reaching for one of the few remaining sheets of paper. —So… Uh… Oh, this is even worse… — she muttered, while skimming through the text. —Hey, Sparkles, your Aunt was having really serious issues. Are you sure she never mentioned a thing?

—She didn't- Why? What does that say!?

—It's really bad, I'm… not sure how to explain it— Catra admitted, clearly unsettled. —I'm not sure you should see it either, so I'll just say this: It's more desperate, asking why she had to do that, why she left them, why she *abandoned her*…

—She feels like Shadow Weaver abandoned her?— Adora repeated. —What does that even mean?

—Well, if I'm right…— Catra began, snatching the last letter they had left to check. —Yeah, she- Ah…— the magicat sighed. —She-she hoped to have her back in Mystacor. Castaspella is really desperate, more in this last letter… She says that she'd do *anything* to get her back, to see her again…

—You can't be serious— Glimmer denied, disbelieving. —If it-it were true, it would mean…

—Your dad is wrong…— Bow realized.

—What?— Adora inquired, shocked. —So she wasn't attacked?

—Not by someone else, at the very least— Catra pointed out, trying to answer her question indirectly.

—But… Tha-that's just a theory, right?— she insisted.

—I think I should talk to Auntie as soon as she wakes up— Glimmer considered. —Don't let Dad see this. And… Maybe I should get someone to keep an eye on Aunt Casta from now on.

—Just in case— Catra agreed.

—And what should we tell Micah?

—I'll figure that out. For now, just keep him distracted until I talk to Auntie.

The Queen took deep breaths, slowly, focusing on staying calm, and reminding herself only Castaspella knew what was going on. What they had were nothing more than conjectures…

She soon arrived at the medical bay, talked to the physician, and once she was briefed on her state, she was allowed to visit her.

She waited for only a moment, sitting next to her aunt's bed, before the sorceress stirred awake.

—Ugh…— she groaned, feeling her body quite stiff.

—Auntie!?— Glimmer immediately reacted, reaching for her hand.

—Huh?

—It's me, Auntie…— she insisted, tears forming in her eyes.

—Hi, Dear…— she spoke, breathless. —Is everything… alright?— she asked, before a fit of coughing interrupted her. —Where… am I?— she then managed to ask, finally noticing her surroundings.

—It's- You- A-Auntie, you had an accident.

—Did I? Oh… Yes, I recall now.

—Listen. I- Uh, I'll just be honest: We found your letters.

—My… what?

—We-we didn't know what had happened to you, Dad was going insane, I promised to find out the culprit of what he *thought* had been an attack, and… I checked your room— Glimmer began. Speaking fast so she wouldn't be interrupted, she went on —And then I found the stack of unsent letters you wrote… to… Shadow Weaver.

—Ah… I see— Castaspella sighed, resting her head back on the pillow. —That's quite amusing— she chuckled. That was… far from what the Queen expected. —I can't imagine what you may be thinking— she then sighed, never noticing Glimmer's absolute shock. —But, you know? I used to write that kind of letters to your father after we thought him dead…

—Really!?

—Yes! And while that wasn't the original plan, of course, once he returned I gave them to him. As soon as I could, I mean, not right away. But, well, I thought he should have them. After all, they were a good way for him to catch up with everything that had been going on… At least from my perspective.

—Auntie…— the Queen laughed, albeit to hold back her tears. —That's actually- It-it's really nice.

—I hoped so— the sorceress smiled.

—But… I need to ask: did- Uh, did you do… something to *yourself*?— Glimmer decided to finally ask, looking away. —Ma-maybe… when we found you unconscious, you hadn't been attacked, as Dad thought, but…

—Oh, no, Dear, that's not the case— Castaspella interrupted, as soon as she realized what her niece was asking. —It was a mere accident. Or, well, a very *stupid* accident— she laughed. —To summarize it, and spare you the second-hand embarrassment, I had a situation and didn't want to ask for help, which resulted in me falling and… apparently I passed out.

—You… Oh…— Glimmer let out, relieved. Her chest felt much lighter now. —Well, that's- I'm really sorry, Auntie; please ask for help the next time— she chuckled. —And, uh, would you prefer we keep… those letters… uh, secret from Dad?

—I do…— she admitted, before fully realizing the implications of Glimmer's wording. —Hold on, "we"?

—Oh, well, yeah, I… read the letters with… Bow, Adora and Catra…

—I see…— the sorceress sighed. —Well, as long as they keep the secret too… I don't mind.

—Don't worry, Auntie. Really— the Queen smiled, reaching for her hand. —Now, just recover, I'll let Dad know it was just an accident, and you should be back on your feet soon enough!

—Thank you, Dear. I appreciate the concern— Castaspella smiled back.

When the Queen found her friends again, her father was with them.

Right! She had asked them to keep him busy…

—Hey, guys!— she waved, approaching. —I spoke with Aunt Casta, and…

—She's awake!?

—Yeah, Dad. But she needs rest— his daughter quickly replied. —So, I will tell you what she told me, and all of us will wait until she recovers. No need for any more visits. She'll be out of the medical bay soon enough.

—A-are you sure?— Bow asked, concerned.

His glances between Micah and Glimmer let her understand what he meant, so the Queen only smiled.

—Don't worry. It's all fine— she nodded. —She didn't want to tell me the details, but it seems she had some trouble, didn't want to ask for help and, in her words, did something stupid, so she… uh… fell and passed out. And that was when we found her— she explained.

—Oh… An-an accident— Micah sighed. —That's a relief…

—Yeah, there was nothing to worry about— Glimmer chuckled. — Maybe just about her not wanting to ask for help- But! We can be sure no one attacked her!

—Yeah, you're right— he nodded.

—Well, that's certainly good news, isn't it?— Adora commented.

—Very much, yeah. If we had someone randomly attacking people after everything we did to secure peace, I would go insane— Catra scoffed.

—Anyways!— Glimmer interrupted. —Wanna have dinner together later?

—Sure!— her friends immediately replied.

—You are invited too, Dad— she clarified, noticing his dejected expression.

—I- Really?

—Yeah, I think that's a good idea— Bow nodded.

—Honestly, Melog has been nagging me to ask you a few things about sorcery, so if we could talk over dinner, it'd be great— Catra agreed too.

—Just for the record, we're *not* eating bugs, right?— Adora asked, making everyone laugh.

—No, of course not!— Glimmer assured her, still giggling.

—Aw, what a shame— Micah joked, although not without some degree of honesty.

After that, once Glimmer ordered dinner to be prepared for them, and until it was done, the Queen sat on her desk with a blank sheet of paper.

She took a deep breath, searched for a pen inside her drawer, and found something quite unexpected.

That old purple novelty pen with a curled end on top, crowned with little blue buds.

It made her feel a pang of nostalgia.

She could almost hear herself reading aloud as she wrote “Dear Mom, I know you'll never read this, but I have to say it somewhere. I feel like you... don't respect me” in that journal she had…

A single tear rolled down her cheek at the memory, but a small smile also escaped her lips.

Choosing that pen, she smoothed the sheet of paper and began…

—Dear Mom… I know you’ll never read this, but I certainly wish you would. I feel like you would be… so proud. We have peace, at last. The peace you wanted. Dad is back, and… Everyone is *so happy*. I know… you would love everything about the new Etheria— she cheerfully spoke, writing along. —I have a lot to tell you, so I’ll probably need more paper, but just to start, let me tell you about our new friends…

End Notes

Alright! That's it! :D

So, uh, (something happened to my PC while I was writing this note, so this is take 2)

Well, Casta's stupid accident was inspired by the one my mom recently had <("^_^) She calls it that, and docs don't even believe it when she explains it...

But anyways, she'll be fine :)

Many thanks for reading, I hope you enjoyed it!! :D

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